Document 4: Legal Framework: The Investment Code Act, 2019

This document summarises the main law governing investment in Uganda and UIA itself. It is an explanatory summary only. For exact wording, always consult the Act, and for legal interpretation speak to a qualified lawyer.

The Act at a Glance: The Investment Code Act, 2019 is Act 6 of 2019. The President assented to it on 20 February 2019 and it became operational on 29 March 2019. It repealed the earlier Investment Code Act, Cap. 92.

Purpose: The Act revises, modernises and replaces the earlier Investment Code. It aligns the law with the Constitution, continues the Uganda Investment Authority in existence, sets out the Authority's objects and redefines its functions. It also covers the promotion, facilitation, monitoring and evaluation of investment.

Main Topics Covered: The Act's contents include:

- Continuation and functions of the Uganda Investment Authority.
- Minimum investment capital requirements for investment registration.
- Investment registration and registration requirements.
- Foreign investment, including a definition of a foreign investor.
- Investment in scarce resources.
- Application for, issue of and revocation of an investment certificate.
- Investment of surplus funds and compliance with the Public Finance Management Act, 2015.
- Schedule 2: priority areas for investment.

Points Highlighted by Legal Commentators: Commentary from law firms notes that the Act strengthens UIA as a one-stop investment centre, provides for the financing and auditing of the Authority, and aligns protection from expropriation with the Constitution, including prior payment of compensation. It provides for the removal of the Director General (previously called the Executive Director). It introduces an alternative dispute resolution route under the Arbitration and Conciliation Act, Cap. 4, and retains the investor protections from the earlier law. Commentators also note that the Act lists criteria for qualifying for investment incentives and introduces a penalty provision in Section 19. Check the text of the Act for exactly which conduct that penalty covers.

Terminology Note: The Act speaks of an investment certificate, while UIA's website and guides speak of an investment licence. In practice they refer to the same authorisation issued by UIA. Document 2 explains how to apply.

Priority Areas: Schedule 2 of the Act lists priority areas for investment. A 2022 UIA presentation referred to 26 priority areas specified in the Code. Check the current Schedule in the Act before relying on any figure.

Where to Read the Full Text: The Investment Code Act, 2019 is published on ULII (Uganda Legal Information Institute) as a PDF under a Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 licence, and it is also

listed in the UIA Download Centre (see Document 7). Incentives that arise from other laws are explained in Document 5.

This summary is for general information and is not legal advice. For questions about how the Act applies to your situation, contact UIA or consult a lawyer.

Sources: Investment Code Act, 2019 (ULII PDF); PwC Uganda legal alert on the Investment Code Act, 2019 (June 2019); World Services Group commentary on the Investment Code Act, 2019; UIA presentation on Uganda's Investment Environment (March 2022). Last verified: 21 October 2026.